country's historians. How long will we go on cursing the British saying that an injustice was done to us. Who is stopping us from writing (history)? … We do not have to get in conflict with anyone … We will write history as we see it, and because it will contain the truth, it will be popular … Can our historians not make 200 personalities who helped Indians reach here, and 25 dynasties which gave a lot to the world, a part of our history? This is the time when our historians need to rewrite our history as per a new vision,' he said.[22]

Speaking at a seminar on the fifth-century Gupta king Skandagupta, he said, 'India never invaded any foreign territory, but we have our own heroes like Skandagupta who defeated the Hunas when they had conquered a large part of Asia and Europe and had seemed invincible. It is unfortunate that our children don't know about the great ruler who extended our boundaries from Afghanistan to Junagadh. It is also unfortunate that his merits and contributions are ignored and there are not enough historical references about him.'[23] Modi's New India is thus as much about redefining the Indian past as it is about reshaping the future; as domestic in its ambition as it is global.

On the first Diwali after the Ram Temple decision in 2020, for example, the only news a prominent Hindi newspaper had on the front page of its UP district editions was a picture of hundreds of thousands of lamps lighting up the city and Yogi Adityanath's assertion that this was the 'dream of five centuries coming true'. This banner headline was accompanied by others like '*Gaurav-bodh se alokit Ram-Nagri*' (A feeling of pride lights up Ram's town), which used a poetic and religious turn of phrase to convey a political message. Another front-page headline declared: '*Ayodhya Banegi Vaishwik Nagri*' (Ayodhya will become a global city).[24] Not only did Yogi Adityanath emphatically declare that 'after 492 years' Sri Ram Janmabhoomi was glittering with celebration,[25] the UP government also distributed formal 'certificates' of participation to those who joined the ritual by lighting a virtual lamp through a special government website.[26] Such a website would, of course, serve a religious purpose as well as yield a database of prospective BJP